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Conflict Resolution in High-Stress Environments

Hi. I'm Haley.

My background: Business development & leadership

- Built a skydiving business from \$50K to over \$1M.
- Managed tandem and student skydiving operations.
- Skydiving is a high-stress environment and according to the arborists I know, so is the tree industry from time to time.
- I'm not a psychologist or therapist.
- Fun fact about me...
I **HATE** conflict.



Job sites are a high stress environment.

- Even for the most experienced arborists, job sites can be high stress environments.
 - Constant noise (chainsaws, heavy equipment, roadside exposure)
 - Time & production pressure
 - Multiple moving parts happening at once
 - Physical risk — working at height, falling limbs, machinery nearby
- These factors intensify the environment and add pressure



Stress magnifies conflict.

- Elements at a jobsite that tend to make people more “reactive”
 - Pressure
 - Fatigue
 - High Stakes

A small disagreement in a normal setting might be manageable, but when these factors are at play, a small disagreement can easily spiral into conflict.



Poor conflict management leads to toxic culture.

Poor conflict management will...

- Cause resentment & drama
- Lower team morale
- Break down trust among team
- Cause poor communication
- Increase turnover rate
- Cause burnout & unnecessary stress
- Cause inefficiency

The Psychology Behind Conflict.

We must first understand the natural human response to conflict in order to overcome that response and manage conflict logically and effectively.



What Drives Conflict?

**STRESS
RESPONSES**

EGO

**COGNITIVE
BIAS**

**EMOTIONAL
TRIGGERS**



The psychology behind conflict - Stress Response

It's not just your "feelings"... It's **neuroscience**.

Human Stress Responses: Fight, Flight, Freeze, or Fawn

- Biological response to perceived threats (even if the "threat" is just a disagreement)
- When we feel stressed or attacked, our brain activates the amygdala, which controls our survival instincts.
- This triggers the fight, flight, freeze, or fawn response, making it harder to think rationally or respond to the situation effectively.
- In high-stress environments, where stakes are already high, people are more likely to react emotionally rather than logically.



The psychology behind conflict - Ego

Ego & Identity: Why We Take Conflict Personally

Ego plays a huge role in conflict - especially in industries where competence, experience, and authority are highly valued.

- When someone questions our decisions, skills, or authority, it can feel like a personal attack on our identity
- The brain processes social rejection or criticism similarly to physical pain
- Defensiveness kicks in, causing people to focus on proving themselves right rather than solving the problem.

If we understand and acknowledge that ego is a natural factor in conflict, we can separate the problem from us as a person and focus on resolution rather than being "right."



The psychology behind conflict - Cognitive Bias

Cognitive Biases: The Mental Shortcuts That Fuel Conflict

Our brains rely on shortcuts (biases) to make decisions quickly — but in conflict, these biases can sometimes make things worse.

- **Confirmation Bias:** We look for evidence that supports our views and ignore information that contradicts us.
- **Attribution Error:** We assume other people's mistakes are due to their personality ("they're careless"), but our own mistakes are due to circumstances ("I was just in a hurry").
- **Negativity Bias:** We remember negative interactions more than positive ones, making small conflicts feel bigger than they really are.

By recognizing these biases, we can pause and reframe our perceptions before escalating a conflict unnecessarily.



The psychology behind conflict - Emotional Triggers

Emotional Triggers: The Hidden Landmines in Conflict

Many conflicts aren't actually about what they seem — they're often triggered by deeper, personal experiences.

- Someone reacting strongly to feedback might have past experiences of being criticized unfairly.
- A coworker overreacting to a small mistake might feel deeply insecure about their performance.
- A leader getting angry when challenged might feel like their authority is being questioned, making them defensive.

If we recognize emotional triggers (others' and our own), we can respond with empathy instead of escalating the situation.



Conflict Resolution Toolbox



Conflict Survival Skills.

Your Conflict Resolution Toolbox

- **Self-Awareness** – Recognizing your own emotions and reactions.
- **Pause** – Controlling impulsive responses.
- **Empathy** – Understanding others' emotions, responses, and perspectives.
- **Focus Forward** – Keep the conversation focused on productivity.

Think about these tools before you need to use them.

Familiarize yourself with them in a calm controlled setting so that you can identify them quickly and use them in a high stress setting.

Conflict Resolution Tool - Self Awareness

Identify

Learn to identify when you may be experiencing a stress response.

"You have to name it to tame it."

- Fight - Escalation
- Flight - Avoidance
- Freeze - Unable to process or respond
- Fawn - Appeasing

Act

Use these physiological cues to calm the nervous system in tense moments.

- Take a deep breath
- Press your thumb and middle finger together
- Press your feet into the floor
- If you can - drink some water

Conflict Resolution Tool - Pause

When a situation is escalating: PAUSE. Take a breath. Think.

What happens for you...

- Provides time to stop impulsive reactions
- Activates logical thinking rather than emotional response
- Lowers stress & tension
- Gives you control over the conversation
- Prevents escalation

What happens for them...

- It disrupts their momentum
- It creates uncertainty triggering them to use logical thinking rather than emotional response
- It signals composure and confidence
- It makes them listen and pay closer attention

Conflict Resolution Tool - Empathy

How to “Empathy”

- Recognize their stress response (fight, flight, freeze, fawn)
- Listen and acknowledge before responding
- **Identify the hidden need behind their reaction**
- Give acknowledgment and validation before moving forward

Conflict Resolution Tool - Focus Forward

Keep it productive - Move things forward

- Shift from complaints to solutions
 - "What do you think would help?"
- Avoid circular arguments
- Set clear next actions

Final Takeaway

Conflict is an opportunity, not a threat.

- Instead of seeing conflict as something to avoid, try to use it as a tool for overall improvement.
- Teams that handle conflict effectively:
 - Have stronger more meaningful communication
 - Build trust and respect among the team
 - Improve safety and efficiency

Sources & Resources

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